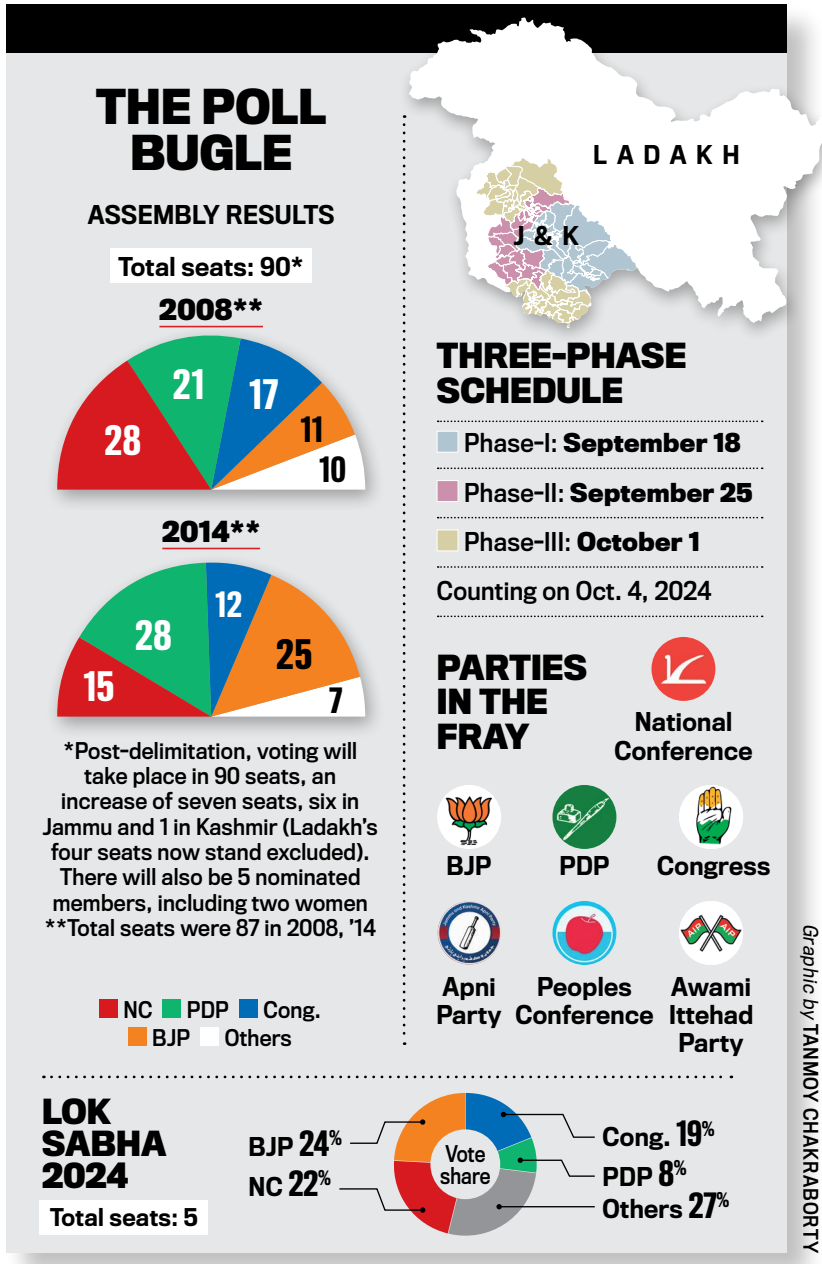




Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

COME SEPTEMBER, JAMMU AND KASHMIR WILL SEE AN ASSEMBLY ELECTION AFTER A DECADE, giving hope to the people that they will finally see local representation in government decision-making. The polls for the 90 assembly seats of Jammu (43) and Kashmir (47) will be held in three phases, from September 18 to October 1. This will be the first assembly election since the abrogation of Article 370 and the downgrading of the erstwhile state to Union territory (UT) status in August 2019. J&K has been under direct central rule for over six years now, since June 2018.

In what is a positive sign, all the political parties are convinced about the process. The Lok Sabha election in June saw the National Conference (NC) and the BJP securing two seats each in Kashmir and Jammu, respectively (the fifth was won by Awami Ittehad Party (AIP) candidate Sheikh Abdul Rashid, popularly known as Engineer Rashid). The BJP had dominated the electoral turf in Jammu with over 24 per cent vote share in the general election, followed by the Congress (19.4 per cent). The NC (22.3 per cent) and the Peoples Democratic Party (8.5 per cent) held sway in the Valley.

The NC and Congress have now announced a tie-up, which is likely to upset the BJP's prospects. So much so, it spurred Union home minister Amit Shah into calling it an 'unholy alliance'. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi were in J&K for two days, beginning August 21, where they said that restoration of statehood is the party's priority, a comment that has drawn much public support. "This has never happened before," said Rahul. "Union territories have become states, but this is a first for a state becoming a UT. We are very clear...it is a priority for us that the people of J&K and Ladakh get their democratic rights back."

The alliance almost didn't come through. The NC and Congress sealed the deal after two rounds of frenetic deliberations on August 26, on the eve of filing of nominations for the first phase. The NC will be contesting 51 seats, while the Congress will field candidates in 32. One seat each has been allotted to INDIA allies CPI(M) and the J&K Panthers Party. Interestingly, five seats—Doda, Banihal, Bhaderwah, Nagrota and Sopore—will see 'friendly contests', since local leaders on both sides have refused to cede space to the other. Congress general secretary K.C. Venugopal says the objective of the alliance was to "protect the soul of Kashmir". "The BJP has had alliances with both the NC and the PDP earlier," he said, hitting back at Shah for criticising the NC manifesto. "Every political party has its manifesto and promises; we too have ours. When we form a government, there will be a common minimum programme."

Extrapolating from the assembly segment-wise results of the general election, the NC will be the frontrunner this poll, especially with the Congress by its side. Party vice-president Omar Abdullah had lost the Baramulla seat, but data show that the NC secured a lead in 34 assembly segments in Kashmir (it did not field candidates in the two seats in Jammu). As for the BJP, it defeated the Congress candidates in the two seats in Jammu, but there was a steep decline in vote share, from 46.7 per cent in 2019 to 24.4 per cent in 2024 (it did not contest in the Valley). Of the 36 assembly constituencies in the Jammu and Udhampur LS seats, it led in 29. The BJP enjoys strong support in Hindu-dominated Jammu where it won 25 seats in the 2014 assembly election, and